# Do posture correctors work? 7 ways to improve your posture

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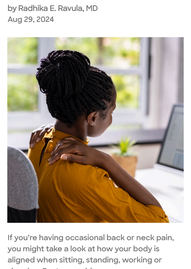

If you're having occasional back or neck pain, you might take a look at how your body is aligned when sitting, standing, working or sleeping. Posture problems are common contributors to spine and pain issues, especially in recent years as more people are working remotely.

Even if your posture isn't as perfect as you'd like it to be, you can take steps to improve it—both with and without tools like a posture corrector.

By focusing on good posture, you can build habits that relieve pain and keep your spine healthy in the long term.

## Why is good posture important?

Good posture is important because when your posture is correct, your whole body is in alignment. This means you're not putting pressure on your spine or other structures that could lead to chronic pain. The right posture allows your body to move and work like it should.

Maintaining proper posture can help:

- **Prevent pain:** When you have good alignment in your body, it reduces stress and pressure on your discs, muscles and joints. And that leads to a lower risk of back pain, shoulder pain and neck pain.
- **Reduce your risk of headaches:** Sometimes, headaches actually start in the upper part of the spine, known as the cervical spine. Neck pain—called cervicalgia—can lead to cervicogenic headaches, where the headache comes from problems in your neck.
- **Improve your breathing:** Posture can also improve your breathing. When you're sitting or standing up straighter, it gives more room for your lungs to expand.

## What is a posture corrector?

Posture correctors include a range of wearable devices that are designed to help you improve your posture. Different posture correctors work in different ways, but the most important thing to know about posture correctors is that they are a short-term—not a long-term—solution.

Some types of posture correctors that you may see include:

- Shoulder and back braces that keep you in the right position
- Sensors that beep or vibrate as a reminder
- Posture-correcting bras that have built-in support

## Do posture correctors work?

Posture correctors work only as a temporary support. If you want to get a jump start on better posture and use a posture corrector as a reminder, that's OK. But they shouldn't be used for a long period of time because you don't want to get dependent on them.

For example, you should only use a shoulder or back brace for an hour or two a day. If you wear a brace all day, your back muscles are going to slowly weaken. Instead of helping your posture, this muscle weakening could ultimately make the problem worse, not better.

## 7 ways to improve your posture without a corrector

Often, posture correctors aren't needed. If you rely on your own skills and build healthy posture habits rather than using a posture corrector, you're likely to have success.

### 1. Be mindful of your posture

Good posture starts with mindfulness. While standing, think of a line going from the ceiling to the floor. You want your ears, shoulders, hips, knees and ankles all in a row on that vertical line. When you're holding yourself in this straight line, imagine that your head is pulled toward the ceiling, making you stretch upright.

### 2. Rearrange your workspace

It's hard to sit upright when you have a laptop in your lap or you're slouching over to see a screen. When working on your computer or laptop, make sure your screen is sitting on a desk or table at eye level. If you spend a lot of time sitting to work, consider investing in an ergonomic chair that's designed to help you sit in the right position.

### 3. Prop up electronic devices

If you're constantly bending your neck to look at your phone or propping your phone in between your shoulder and ear to talk, it can put pressure on your spine and neck muscles—commonly known as tech neck. Instead, prop up electronic devices so that they are at eye level.

### 4. Listen to your body when you sleep

With sleep, the right posture varies based on whether you're a back, side or stomach sleeper. If you have a spine issue and you're trying to sleep in a position that's not comfortable, that's your body telling you to shift. If you find a comfortable position that makes your body happy, that's the right position for you.

### 5. Stretch your muscles

Stretching is very helpful to keep the body and spine in alignment. Start your day by doing stretching exercises the first thing when you get out of bed. Some people even do stretches for back pain in their bed before they get up. Incorporating stretching relaxes your muscles and prevents them from getting stiff.

### 6. Keep your muscles strong

Along with stretching, exercises that strengthen your muscles help maintain good posture. Many people choose Pilates or yoga for lower back pain and posture-related problems. Even if you're just getting started, these options can be modified to fit your needs. For example, older adults often benefit from chair yoga.

### 7. Move often

If you spend most of your day sitting at work, at school, in the car or at home, it's important to make time to get up and move. Some people set a timer or an alarm as a reminder to take a break and walk around. Aim to get up and move at least every two hours.

## Do posture correctors work? Sometimes—but consistent habits are the key.

If posture is the main issue behind your back, neck or shoulder pain, it can take several weeks or months to make it a habit and see improvement. Building good posture is like when you start to drive. You have to make a conscious effort to learn the signals and pedals. Then, after some time, it becomes a habit, and you do it without giving it much thought.

If you're mindful and follow some simple steps to improve posture, you'll eventually see a big payoff in terms of staying strong and flexible. Even if you already have chronic pain, good posture habits can also prevent your condition from continuing to get worse. When it comes to posture, it's never too late to start.

## About the Author

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